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1989 - Manifesto

COMMON STATEMENT OF THE EUROPEAN GREENS FOR THE 1989 ELECTIONS TO
THE EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT

P R E A M B L E

We European Greens ultimately envisage a new concept for Europe: a Europe of autonomous regions without any borders. Our Europe would have a decentralised structure and a democratic and social organisation in line with green principles - for example regions with self-determination, local production for local needs using energy-saving, non-polluting methods of production. We seek international cooperation on a large scale, wherever necessary, to solve our common problems and want as many reciprocal cultural contacts as possible.

Green parties are campaigning for one Europe of regions without military alliances, for an ecological, social and democratic development, for a Common House of Europe which can only be achieved by all peoples of Europe working together. This is neither possible in a bloc-divided Europe nor in a Western European Superstate nor with the existing North-South economic gap.

The European Greens are concerned that the Single Market will be profoundly unecological. The whole "1992 project" is to create a new economic and military superpower in West Europe. Its central commitment to expanding consumption is quite unsustainable and even in its own terms bound to fail. The price of this failure to the citizens and the environment of Europe will be considerable.

For 30 years the European Community has narrowly identified the "Europe of business" as the only concept of Europe. We run for the European Parliament because we have an alternative view of Europe.

European cooperation should essentially be based on Europe as a whole biosphere. Already existing institutions, such as the CSCE or the Council of Europe could play a more decisive role in elaborating a new common modus vivendi for all the countries of Europe. The neutral and non-aligned states, together with the countries of the EFTA, could develop a new dynamic in the balance of power within today's divided Europe. We understand the

opposition within the EC as in Denmark and we reject the unilateral harmonisation undertaken with non-EC countries like Austria, Sweden, Finland and Switzerland. We support these Green parties in their opposition to their countries joining the EC. Furthermore, in the present climate of perestroika European cooperation cannot be limited to Western Europe and the states of NATO, but we must seize the chance to enter into a dialogue with other countries such as Hungary, Poland, Yugoslavia, the CSSR, or the former Baltic states.

Although we are seeking election to the European Parliament, we are acutely aware that the EEC institutions are deeply undemocratic. We will of course use our Green vision of Europe to promote the democratisation of all institutions, but in the immediate term we will demand full and open access to all the information and decision-making processes of the Commission and the Council of Ministers. Our guiding principle, however, is that no authority be held at a higher level than is absolutely necessary.

Brussels, Belgium, March 13th, 1989

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Sustainable economy

Greens are committed to a radical sharing of wealth-between continents and between generations, not only between classes. This means shifting economic priorities from consumption to conservation; away from the self-defeating economic growth of the Single Market and towards sustainable regional economies.

The momentum of 1992 may bring a temporary surge of classic economic growth as certain businesses borrow, expand and advertise on a bigger scale than ever before. However the stated objectives of 1992 - to create a single trading block able to compete in world markets and an internal market offering reasonably equal benefits to all its members - are, we believe, mutually exclusive. Furthermore, we are in no doubt that the demands of the world economy will overwhelm the demands for a fair internal market and the needs of Europeans for a healthy environment and social justice. The sort of "leaner and fitter" industrial sector being prepared to fight for world markets has already brought higher unemployment, exaggerated already serious regional distortions and allowed industry to ride rough-shod over environmental considerations.

We think that taxes and social security contributions on labour should be reduced in favour of a system of environmental taxes on goods and resources that are scarce and on production modes and products that threaten the environment, damage human health or reflects unjust relations, e.g. with or without third world countries.

International solidarity

By becoming more thrifty and self reliant in Europe and by promoting similar strategies for poor countries, the real path to global economic sustainability can be opened up. The European Greens want to see a radical eradication of the debt burden.

Today Western Europe, together with the United States, Canada, Japan and some OPEC countries is one of the richest regions of a world in which most of the population lives in poverty and want. Approximately 50% of the world's population control just 5% of world income, almost 1 billion people live in permanent poverty, if not famine. This situation is the result of centuries of colonisation and political and economic neo-colonisation. Further, some EEC states still occupy colonial possessions.

The oppression of the majority of third world peoples by the debt crisis and the "structural adjustment" measures of the IMF and the world bank dramatically demonstrate the inequality of power between poor and rich countries despite their formal independence. European countries, governments and financial institutions have a heavy responsibility in this situation.

The trading relationships between the EEC and the poor countries of the world have not benefitted these countries, particularly those with "preference" arrangements through the Lomé conventions. The Lomé agreements solidify the neo-colonial trade patterns between the EC and the ACP countries rather than enable the ACP countries to achieve economic self-reliance.

In the framework of the present negotiations for the fourth Lomé convention, the European Greens are opposed to all alignment of the EEC policies with the policies of the IMF and the World Bank.

Greens support a ban on all kinds of waste exports to third world countries.

We also support the right to self-determination and support self-reliant economic and social development of peoples in third world countries.

Environment

We are particularly concerned that the White Book treats rules protecting the environment and human health as potential trade barriers and regret that the articles in the Single European Act concerning environmental and social matters are weakly worded compared to those articles dealing with economics.

The European Greens believe that ecological and health considerations must be given the highest political priority.

The European Greens would like to see a publically-accountable, independent European Environmental Impact Assessment Agency with adequate funding. The purpose would be to ensure that international conventions, signed by European countries, are implemented in the different countries. It should also monitor and collect data on the environmental quality in Europe and make proposals on how to solve environmental problems.

The local right to ban the importation of goods for environmental and health reasons will be essential if the trend towards ecological dumping is to be reversed and a progressive competition to create "eco-regions" stimulated.

Reversing the major changes in ecology in the North Sea, the Mediterranean and our rivers will require measures to end the run-off from fertilizers and pesticides, and an end to sewage and toxic waste dumping.

The quickest, safest and cheapest way to cut down on air pollution is to embark on a serious programme of efficient energy production and an over-all reduction of energy consumption.

Energy

We would therefore demand nuclear research and investment budgets shifted to renewable sources of energy (from the sun, wind and waves for example), clean burning of fossil fuels and conservation.

The European Greens unequivocally oppose the use of civil or military nuclear technology, as an outdated, expensive inhuman and extremely dangerous technology that creates environmental problems persisting for thousands of years. We believe that those states with nuclear plants should pay for any safety systems and emergency planning that other countries are obliged to install.

To this end, the European Greens want to abolish Euratom and transfer all funding to research and development of efficient and non-polluting energy systems.

Transport

We will promote European transport policies based on revitalisation of existing waterway networks (canals and coastal shipping) and a coherent rail network (which does not need High Speed Trains over short distances and through tunnels under the Alps) instead of road and air transport.

Therefore large schemes favouring road vehicles such as the Channel Tunnel between England and France, the Store Bælt bridge in Denmark, the Scanlink from Oslo to Hamburg and Alpine tunnels etc. should be abandoned.

Biotechnology

The European Greens are very critical of biological engineering. We oppose the introduction of genetically manipulated organisms (GMO) into the environment because the ecological risks are unknown. We object to the treatment of living beings as objects. Patenting plants and animals must not be allowed because it threatens biological diversity and rural economies in the third world. It also makes agriculture all over the world even more dependent on overpowerful transnational companies.

Ethical codes must apply to all genetic engineering involving human kind, e.g. embryo manipulations, prenatal diagnoses and genetic screening. The European Greens think a wide public debate is necessary. Genetic research and application must be evaluated with ecological, social and ethical problems in mind.

Agriculture

After 30 years of Common Agricultural Policy the results are disastrous. The CAP is designed to transform Europe's agriculture into an agglomeration of a few agrobusiness companies. It forces farmers to industrialize and chemicalize production more and more. This industrialization of agriculture is one of the main reasons for the disappearing of more and more plant species. The CAP is increasing social imbalances among farmers. Who profits from the CAP are not the farmers but agrobusiness corporations. Storage, administration, distribution, and transformation of the surpluses is now using up 75% of the CAP budget. The inadequacies of the system have been underlined by evidence of massive fraud. Every new push for rationalization and centralization results in new profits for the chemical and machinery industry, but not for farmers and consumers. The CAP destroys ecologically sound ways

of farming, decentralized distribution systems, and healthy food, and tries to adapt nature to industry.

Green agricultural policies demand:

- * support and promotion of organic farming
- * reduction of pesticide and fertilizer use
- * a ban on genetic engineering
- * regionalization of the agricultural policy to promote regional self-reliance
- * abolition of any direct and indirect export subsidies
- * drastic reduction of agricultural external trade
- * safeguards for fair prices in trade with third world countries
- * reduction of livestock food imports
- * protection for animals against industrialized farming and amend to the use of chemicals and hormones
- * changes in the EC prices system that structurally benefit small farming enterprises and disadvantage big industrial farming corporations.

Women and men

Women and men are still waiting for equality in most areas of their lives.

We believe equal rights for women depends on both men and women having the same freedom of choice when faced with a decision. We want concrete steps to make these equal rights a reality, such as antidiscrimination laws in the work place, in the home, in social life, in education and the legal system. In particular we demand the unrestricted right of women to make decisions about their own bodies, including abolition of any criminalization of abortion. Also, protection for raped and abused women and girls must be strengthened - their rights in court for example; an end to discrimination between rape within and outside marriage; and financial support for women's houses and night taxis.

We will therefore campaign for the sort of society that gives both men and women real equality and the chance to blend child care with a full and satisfactory life outside the home.

Work

We feel high priority should be given to the problems of unemployment now standing at about 10% overall and expected to rise sharply as the 1992-process bites. We will promote measures to ensure that the rewards, pains and pleasures of work and the benefits for unemployed are more equally shared and, in particular, will demand full rights for Trade Unions to cooperate on equivalent transnational levels when faced with transnational employers.

We support moves towards more flexible working patterns both in the working week and over lifetimes. However, the power to choose new ways of organising work should rest with the individual. We emphasize that there should be a differentiation between good work and the sort of work that is damaging to the environment or to people. As the first step towards sharing the work that needs to be done, we demand a reduction of working hours.

We are looking forward to a reconversion of industry based on more natural processes of production, on waste reduction and recycling systems and without the toxic chemical components.

Human rights

The European Greens believe that all Member states should abolish the death penalty totally and for ever and openly protest against the death penalty wherever it is used.

Today the EEC governments are coordinating restrictions on civil liberties and expansion of police control. The ministers of interior affairs are taking part in talks called TREVI (terrorism, extremism, international violence) about intelligence service and police cooperation and Europe-wide data exchange and joint surveillance. We demand parliamentary control of all security services.

Registration, surveillance and police restrictions in all West European states are most intensive for labour immigrants. The so-called Schengen agreement enables the government to perfectly close EEC borders to refugees seeking help and asylum. If a refugee is refused asylum in one EEC country, she or he won't get asylum in any other EEC country. For immigrants the borders will be more closed than ever. In almost every part of the EEC immigrants are discriminated against and often lack most democratic rights. We demand equal rights for resident immigrants, politically and economically, and oppose any attempts to restrict the right for a political asylum for refugees.

At the same time, in many parts of Europe racism and xenophobia are on the rise. The "European idea" is developing into Eurochauvinism. Green parties will campaign vigorously against the racist, neofascist, anti-democratic and inhuman movements and parties, and will try to form broad alliances with other democratic and anti-racist organisms for a European movement against racism and chauvinism.

Disarmament and Demilitarization

Europe today is divided into two heavily armed military alliances, with only a few countries being neutral or non-aligned. Any war in Europe, be it nuclear or conventional, would leave nothing of what was supposed to be defended. The Soviet disarmament initiatives today are a magnificent opportunity to end the arms race and even reverse it into a disarmament race.

But NATO already is planning new "modernizations" in nuclear, chemical, and conventional weapons. In the context of the construction of the "European Pillar" of NATO, the West European states, particularly France and West Germany, are increasing their military cooperation. For this purpose, the military alliance Western European Union (WEU) is being revived and in November 1988 was enlarged by Spain and Portugal. More and more this military integration takes place within the framework of the supposedly "civilian" EEC.

We are campaigning for a maximum of military disintegration

between the Western European states. A nuclear armed superpower EEC under French-West German hegemony is the logical end of these developments. Instead of building a new military bloc within NATO, EC states should respond positively to the Soviet disarmament initiatives either jointly or, if impossible, with independent, unilateral steps. We will use the European election campaign to raise public opposition to increasing European military cooperation and to question the legitimacy of NATO's "modernizations" and to put pressure on Western European governments to respond accordingly to the Soviet disarmament initiatives.

CONCLUSION:

The European Greens will be working everywhere to promote the ideas contained within this platform. We will also be urging the citizens of Europe to express their concern for the environment by voting Green in the elections to the European Parliament. In fact, voting Green is probably the only way to get the message across. Staying at home or voting for another party means the message will be lost - a vote will have been wasted.

There is still time to choose the Green way, consciously and democratically. More and more Europeans are doing this. They are choosing to demonstrate their solidarity with the earth, with the poor and with the future generations. They have embraced the politics of life. Please join them and us - only together can we turn our grey earth green.

Adopted by The European Greens at their meeting in Brussels, March 11/12th, 1989